



Around 200 stone heads decorated Tiwanaku's Semi-Subterranean Temple. They may represent the group that founded the city—their flat headdresses denote high status.

ALTHOUGH THE WESTERN ROMAN EMPIRE SEEMED RELATIVELY SECURE IN 400,

within a decade it had suffered a series of disasters. Gothic raids in 401 and again in 405 ravaged northern Italy. Then on the last day of 406, **hordes of Vandals**, joined by two other barbarian groups, the **Alans** and **Sueves**, crossed the frozen Rhine near Mainz, sacked Treveri (modern Trier, Germany) and Remi (modern Reims, France), and forced their way southwest until they reached the Pyrenees.

Meanwhile, the **armies of Britain** had raised up a series of **usurpers** as emperor from 406. The last of these, **Constantine III** (r. 407–11), took most of the remaining Roman troops in Britain and **crossed to Gaul** in spring 407, aiming to seize the throne from the then head of the Western Roman Empire, Honorius. Although he was defeated and captured at Arles in 412, native leaders in Britain had already **expelled the last Roman officials** there in 410—probably in revenge for their abandonment by Constantine's legion. **Britain was now independent from Rome.**

In 408, **Alaric** (r. c. 395–410), leader of the **Visigoths**, invaded **Italy** once more. The Roman



Visigoths ride on Rome

Alaric's sack of Rome in 410 was particularly shocking, as it was the first time the city had fallen since the Gauls took it in 390 BCE.

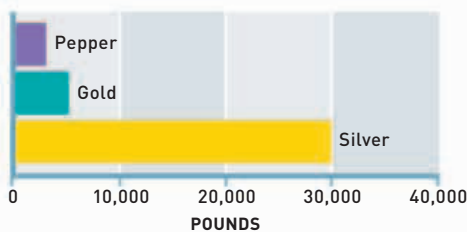
commander Stilicho persuaded the Senate to **agree to pay Alaric a huge bribe** in exchange for leaving the city, but there seems to have been a coup d'état and Stilicho was overthrown and killed. In 409, Alaric had Attalus, the prefect of Rome, declared emperor in an attempt to seize the initiative, but all negotiations failed. So, on August 24, 410, the **Visigoths entered Rome** and subjected it to a **three-day sack**. The event shook the entire Roman world, but Alaric was unable to secure domination over Italy, as he died later the same year.

In South America, **the city of Tiwanaku**, 15 miles (25 km) south

of Lake Titicaca (on the border between modern Peru and Bolivia), **reached its greatest size** in the 5th century, covering an area some 3 sq miles (8 sq km) in extent. Its central area contained a lavish series of **ceremonial buildings and temples**. These included the Semi-Subterranean Temple, decorated with stone heads of humans and supernatural beings, and structures such as the massive and beautifully decorated **Gateway of the Sun**. These were erected by a major pre-Columbian culture that **dominated the Altiplano** (flat high plateau) of Peru and Bolivia, and whose influence extended into northern Bolivia.

Ransom demands

Alaric initially asked for a huge ransom in return for leaving Rome in 410. Even when he moderated his demands, the Senate refused, and so the city was sacked.

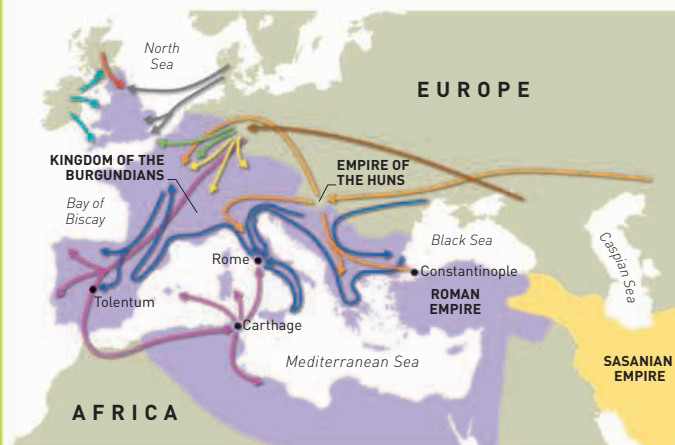


“SO THE **VANDALS**, HAVING **WRESTED LIBYA FROM THE ROMANS** IN THIS WAY, MADE IT THEIR OWN...”

Procopius, Byzantine scholar, from *History of the Wars*, III iv 1, c. 500–550

THE BARBARIANS WHO HAD INITIALLY CROSSED THE RHINE IN 401 had gone on to sack a number of cities before moving southwest into Aquitania and then crossing the Pyrenees into Spain, where they **occupied large swaths of Roman territory**. In 416–18, the Roman army commander Constantius persuaded the **Visigoths under Wallia** (r. 415–18) to invade Spain. There he smashed the Alans and the Siling Vandals, but allowed some of them to settle in southern Spain and left the Asing Vandals and Sueves in possession of northwestern Spain. Wallia was rewarded with official possession of much of southwestern Spain.

On the other side of the Mediterranean in 429, **Boniface**, the Roman Governor of North Africa, revolted against his long-term adversary **Aëtius**, and called on the Siling Vandals for help. The **Vandal king, Gaiseric** (r. 428–77), crossed over the Straits of Gibraltar with—it was said—80,000 of his people and, far from helping Boniface, swiftly occupied most of North Africa. In 435, he made a treaty with the Romans, recognizing his **occupation of Mauretania** (modern Algeria and Morocco). Gaiseric broke this and in 439 his warriors **captured Carthage**, the Roman capital there, and set up an **independent Vandal kingdom**.



The barbarian invasions

Barbarian groups took more and more Roman territory in the first half of the 5th century, leaving the Western emperors virtually powerless.

KEY

- Roman Empire
- Sasanian Empire
- Huns
- Goths
- Alans
- Vandals, Alans, Sueves
- Burgundians
- Franks
- Jutes, Angles, Saxons
- Irish
- Picts

